A Report on the Town Archive

Prepared for the council, spring 2026

Summary

The town archive holds every decision the council has taken since the town was founded, and it has grown faster in the last five years than in the fifty before them. This report describes what was bought, what was moved, and what the council should decide before the next budget.

Storage

4GB of storage was purchased for the archive last spring, which now holds scanned copies of every council decision, every map of the town, and the minutes of each public meeting since the war.

§ 2. Every record is kept in two places, one in the archive and one in the library across the square, so that a fire or a flood in one building can never take the only copy of anything.

2FA protects every account that can change a record, and each clerk carries a key on a ring with the keys to the building. The keys are changed each spring, when the clerks change desks.[1]

The archive was moved twice this year. In March the paper records went from the basement of the town hall to the dry rooms above the library, where the air is kept cool and the light low, and the shelves were numbered again from the start. In June the scans went from the old server in the clerk's office to the new one in the library, which is copied every night to a second machine in the fire station. Both moves were done by the clerks themselves, on weekends, without closing the archive to the public for a single day, and nothing was lost on the way.

The cost of the year was lower than the council had expected. The storage, the shelves and the new server together came to less than the old contract for keeping the paper records in a warehouse outside the town, which the council ended in January. The savings were put into the fund for the roof of the library, which will need to be replaced within the next ten years, and the rest was kept for the shelves of the second reading room.

Visitors came in greater numbers than ever before. Most of them were looking for the history of their own houses, and the new maps made that easier: a visitor can now find the first owner of a house, the year it was built and every change made to it since, in a single afternoon at the reading table. School classes came every month, and two of them made an exhibition of what they found, which was shown in the town hall for the whole of the summer.

The clerks kept a list of every question they could not answer, and the list was shorter than last year's. Most of the questions that remain are about the years when the town had no clerk at all, and the records of those years are kept in the archive of the county, not in ours. The council could ask the county for copies of them, and the clerks have already asked how much the copies would cost and how long they would take to make.

The volunteers who help the clerks on Saturdays have grown from four to eleven. They sort the letters that families give to the archive, write a short note on each one, and put them in boxes by street. Without them the letters given this year would still be waiting in the hall. Two of the volunteers are retired teachers, who now lead the school classes through the reading room and show them how a record is found, read and put back where it belongs, in the right box and on the right shelf, so that the next visitor can find it again.

The council asked last autumn whether the archive could open in the evenings. A trial was run in October and November, two evenings a week, and the reading room was full on each of them, so the clerks propose to keep the evenings open from the spring, with the volunteers taking turns. The evenings would cost the town the heating and the light of the reading room for six hours a week, which the clerks have counted at a little more than the price of the new shelves.

The last question the council asked was whether the archive should keep the letters and photographs that families bring in, or only the records of the council itself. The clerks believe that

[1] The old keys are kept in a sealed envelope in the safe of the town hall.

the archive should keep both, since the families' papers are often the only record of how the town looked and lived, and they ask the council to say so in the rules of the archive.

Results

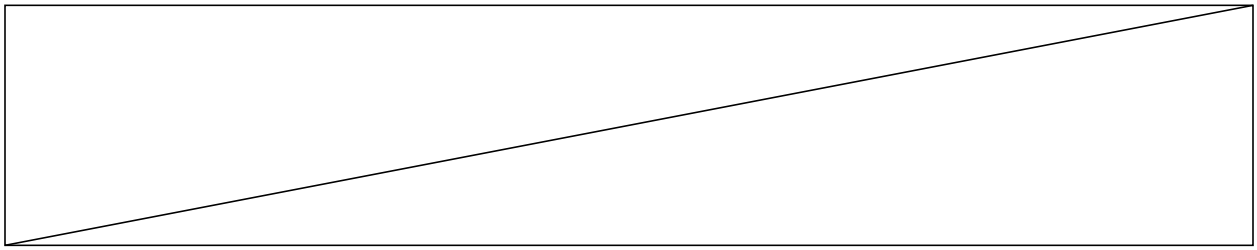


Figure 1: Requests to the archive, by month, over the last two years.

Requests rose in every month but August, when the reading room was closed for the move, and they rose most in the months when the schools came. The clerks expect them to rise again next year.

10GB more will be needed within two years at this rate, and the clerks ask the council to plan for it in the next budget rather than wait until the server is full.

The clerks thank the council for its support, and the volunteers for their Saturdays.

Next steps

The council is asked to approve the evening hours, the rule on families' papers, and the request to the county for copies of the early records.